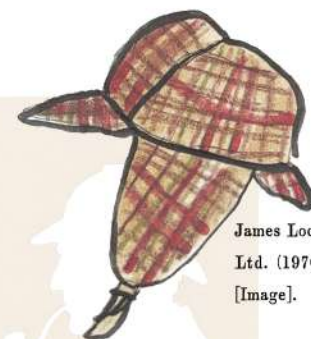




Roskell, R. (1820-21).
Pocket watch [Image].

Lowndes-Yates, C. (1820-1900).
Magnifying glass [Image].

The Unseen Secret



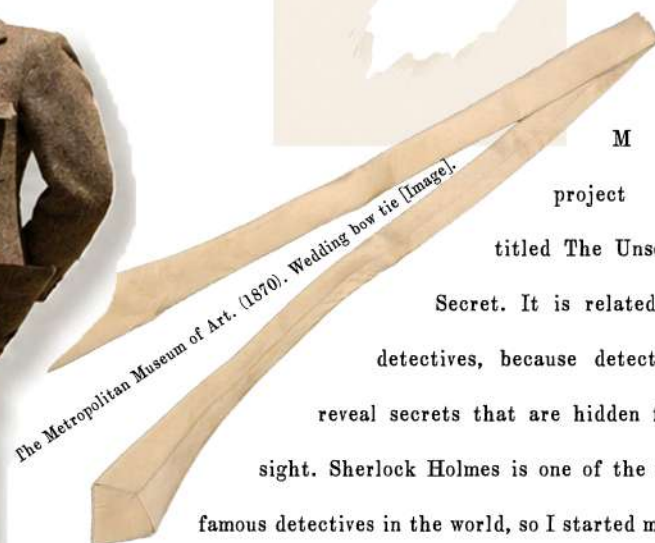
James Lock & Co.
Ltd. (1970s). Hat
[Image].



Paget, S. (1894).
Sherlock Holmes and Dr. Watson [Image].



Ritchie, G. (2009).
Sherlock Holmes [Film still].



The Metropolitan Museum of Art. (1870). Wedding bow tie [Image].

My project is titled The Unseen Secret. It is related to detectives, because detectives reveal secrets that are hidden from sight. Sherlock Holmes is one of the most famous detectives in the world, so I started my research with him.



All images: Jia Xie's own photographs, Sherlock Holmes Museum, London, 2026.

Sherlock Holmes was created by the British writer Arthur Conan Doyle and first appeared in detective fiction in the late nineteenth century. In the stories, Holmes lives at 221B Baker Street in London and investigates cases with Dr Watson.

Holmes is known for his sharp observation, careful logical reasoning, and ability to reveal hidden truths through small clues. He is widely read and also has knowledge of anatomy and chemistry. Because of this, books, experimental tools and chemical bottles became important visual elements in my research into the room at 221B. The magnifying glass, pipe, deerstalker hat and cape are also some of Holmes's most representative objects.

221B: The Sherlock Holmes Museum



**THE
SHERLOCK HOLMES**
**BAKER
STREET W1**
CITY OF WESTMINSTER

Detail of 221B

All images: Jia Xie's own photographs, Sherlock Holmes Museum, London, 2026.

The V.R. bullet marks on the wall stand for Victoria Regina, meaning Queen Victoria. Regina is Latin for queen, so V.R. can be understood as a Victorian sign of loyalty to the Queen. I found this detail interesting, so I used buttons to recreate the shape of V.R. in my own sample.

The small objects on this page show Holmes's personality in a more detailed way. He enjoys smoking and owns many pipes. His briefcase is filled with tools related to investigation, and his accurate shooting is shown through the bullet marks on the wall.

The Victorian style of these objects, together with the hidden mechanism of a gun concealed inside a book, inspired me to think about clothing as both historical and playful. I want my garments to feel vintage, but also to include small interactive details, like hidden devices or secret structures.



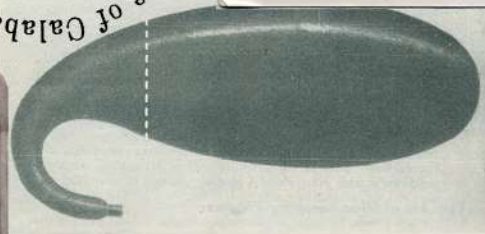
The origins
of the
Calabash
pipe can be
traced back to
southern Africa,
where gourds had been
used as smoking vessels
from around the
seventeenth century.

Later, during the Second
Boer War from 1899 to 1902, British
soldiers encountered this type of pipe in South
Africa and brought it back home as a souvenir.
Because the war caused a shortage of briar
wood, the gourd pipe became an alternative
choice. It gradually became popular among
smokers not only because of its distinctive
shape, but also because its large
internal space could cool
and dry the smoke.

The gourds used to make
Calabash pipes need to be
trained by hand while
they are growing.
Farmers use stones or
clumps of earth to hold
the gourd in place, so
that its neck can form
the correct curve. After
harvesting, workers saw
off the neck and part of
the body of the gourd to
create a trumpet-like
shape.



Abubakar, B. (2018). Calabash Complete [Image].



ORIGINS OF THE CALABASH PIPE

Sitts, J. (2021). Origins of the
Calabash Pipe [Image].



I created a collage by
combining gourds
with Calabash pipes.
I then arranged the
collage with text to
create a more playful
and visually
interesting
composition.

In the original Sherlock Holmes
stories, Holmes was not
necessarily fixed to this specific
type of pipe. However, in
theatre, film and later visual
culture, the Calabash pipe
became closely associated with
him because of its curved,
exaggerated, elegant and easily
recognisable shape. Its
silhouette is especially effective
in presenting the image of a
detective deep in thought.



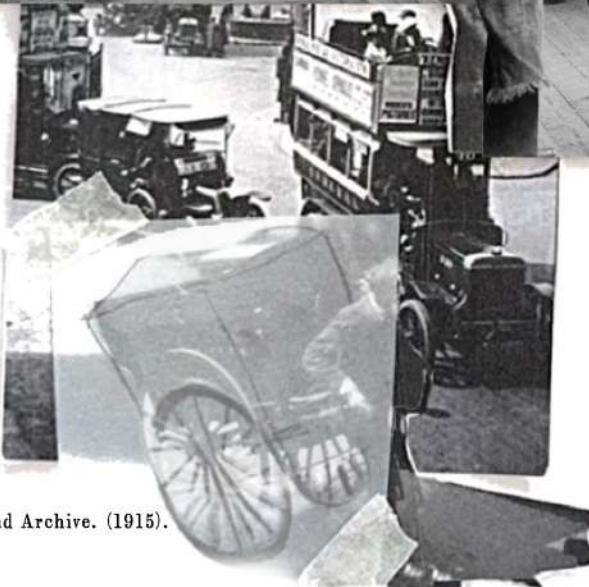
Sagal, B. (1976). Sherlock Holmes in
New York [Film still].

Historic England Archive. (1878).

19th-century London



Because Sherlock Holmes lived in the late nineteenth century, I researched photographs from that period to understand the lifestyle and visual atmosphere of the time. I found the stripes on the houses, the wheels of the carriages and the masts especially interesting. They are simple but powerful design elements.



Historic England Archive. (1915).

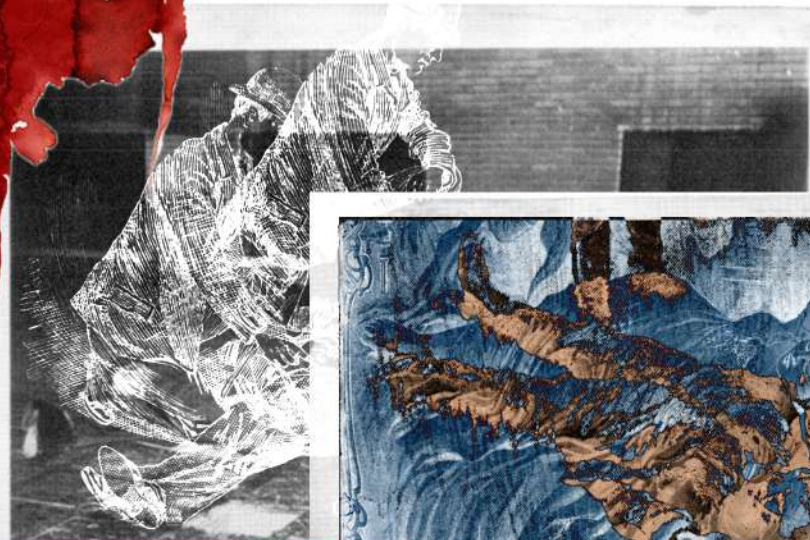
Historic England Archive. (1910).



DEATH
SCENES

The chaotic atmosphere in *Death Scenes* can become one of the visual directions for my garments. For ethical reasons, I did not include real images of dead bodies. Instead, I combined crime scene images with painted bodies from other artworks. The blending effect in Photoshop also helped create a stronger sense of disorder and confusion.

I am interested in the bloodstains, warning tapes and the irregular arrangement of text within these images. The bloodstains and warning tapes can be translated into textile and colour surfaces.



Dunn, K. (2001).
Death Scenes: A Homicide Detective's
Scrapbook [Image].

They found the body [Image].



CRIME SCENE DO NOT CROSS CRIME SCENE DO NOT CROSS

CRIME SCENE DO NOT CROSS CRIME SCENE DO NOT CROSS

CRIME SCENE DO NOT CROSS CRIME SCENE DO NOT CROSS

CRIME SCENE DO NOT CROSS CRIME SCENE DO NOT CROSS

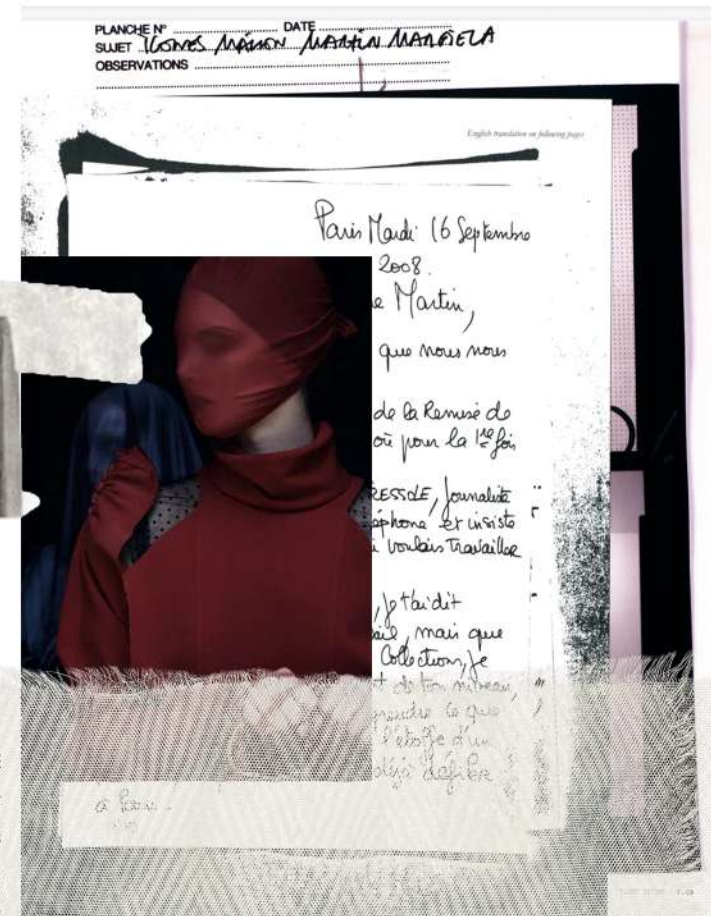
CRIME SCENE DO NOT CROSS CRIME SCENE DO NOT CROSS



Maison Martin Margiela. (2013).



Criminals often hide their identity to avoid being traced. This idea of hidden identity made me think of the masks used by Martin Margiela, although the intention is different. Margiela uses anonymity to shift attention away from the designer and towards the clothes. He does not appear in public, rarely gives interviews, and does not emphasise his name. His garments do not have an obvious logo. They only have a white label with four stitches. On the runway, the models' faces are also often covered. This act of covering and hiding made me think of white tulle. It is common and semi transparent, so it needs several layers to cover what is underneath.



Margiela, M. et al. (2009).

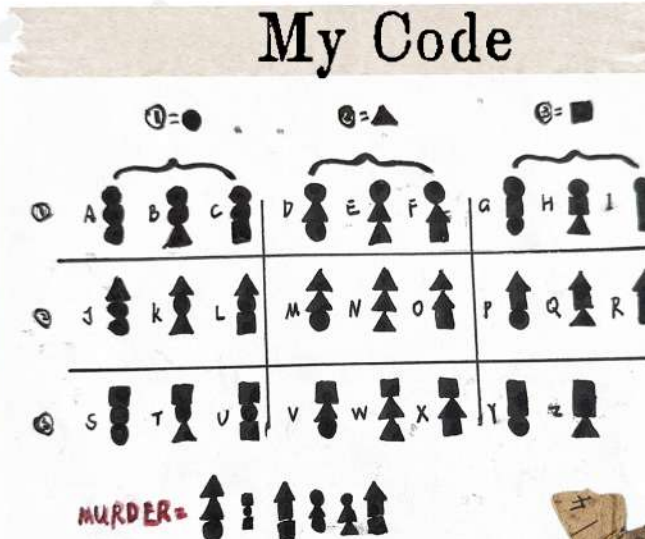
Both the killer and the victim may pass information through codes. The hidden note can also be seen as part of this. So I started to look into cryptography. By

setting and replacing a coding system, I used combinations of three geometric shapes to represent all 26 letters of the alphabet.

combinations of three geometric shapes to represent all 26 letters of the alphabet.



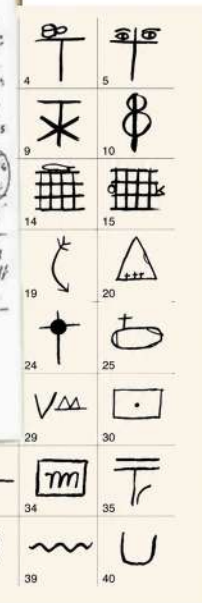
Lunde, P. (2015). The Secrets of Codes [Image].



The National Archives.
(n.d.). MI5's first camera
[Image]. Catalogue reference:
KV 2/27.

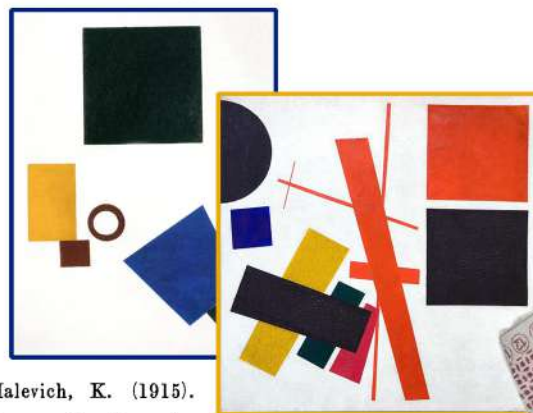


Lunde, P. (2015).
The Secrets of
Codes [Image].





MURDER= 



Malevich, K. (1915).
Suprematism [Image].

A collage of torn, patterned fabric scraps (including stripes and polka dots) and two metal buttons, arranged in a star-like shape.

By studying his work, I translated my code into this kind of visual pattern. I think this can be developed further into print or even silhouette.

Then I thought that burning the fabric might create a feeling closer to the chaotic and unsettling atmosphere I wanted.

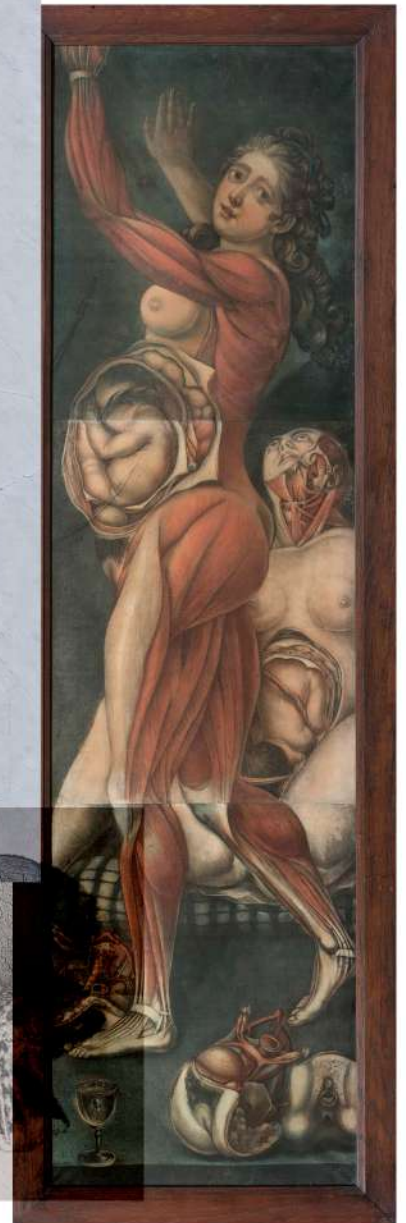
Gautier d'Agoty, J. F. (1745).
Anatomical angel [Image].



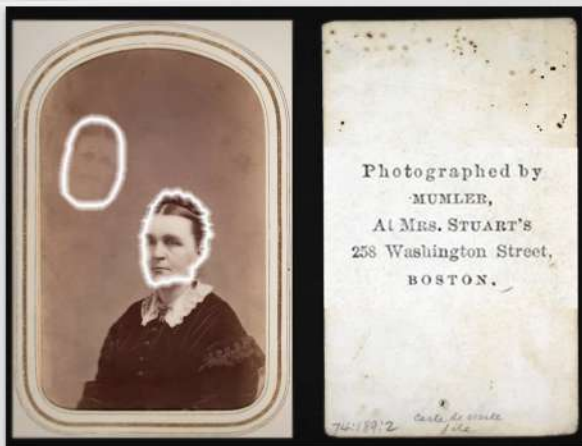
Jacques-Fabien Gautier d'Agoty was an eighteenth-century French artist, printmaker and printer, best known for his coloured anatomical images. His work used colour mezzotint to show muscles, blood vessels, skin and internal body structures with strong visual depth. One of his most famous images is L'Ange anatomique, also known as The Anatomical Angel. It shows a woman's back opened to reveal the spine and muscles, with the back muscles spread out like wings.

I am interested in this image because it combines scientific illustration, exposed body structures, dramatic posture and a religious visual atmosphere. I recreated a collage from his anatomical works because I wanted to express the disorder of the body after a violent death. In a crime scene, the body may no longer appear complete or stable. It can become fragmented, displaced and visually chaotic.

Anatomy



Gautier d'Agoty, J. F. (1746).
Myologie complete en couleur [Image].



Photographed by
MUMLER,
At Mrs. STUART'S
258 Washington Street,
BOSTON.

Spirit photography was a photographic phenomenon that appeared in the mid to late nineteenth century. It refers to photographs in which blurred, translucent, ghost-like figures appear beside or behind the living sitter. Supporters believed these images were spirits of the dead captured by the camera, while sceptics argued that they were likely created through double exposure, layered negatives, darkroom manipulation or other photographic techniques.

In response to this research, I used Photoshop to create an image in the style of spirit photography, showing two ghostly Sherlock Holmes bears appearing in the photograph.

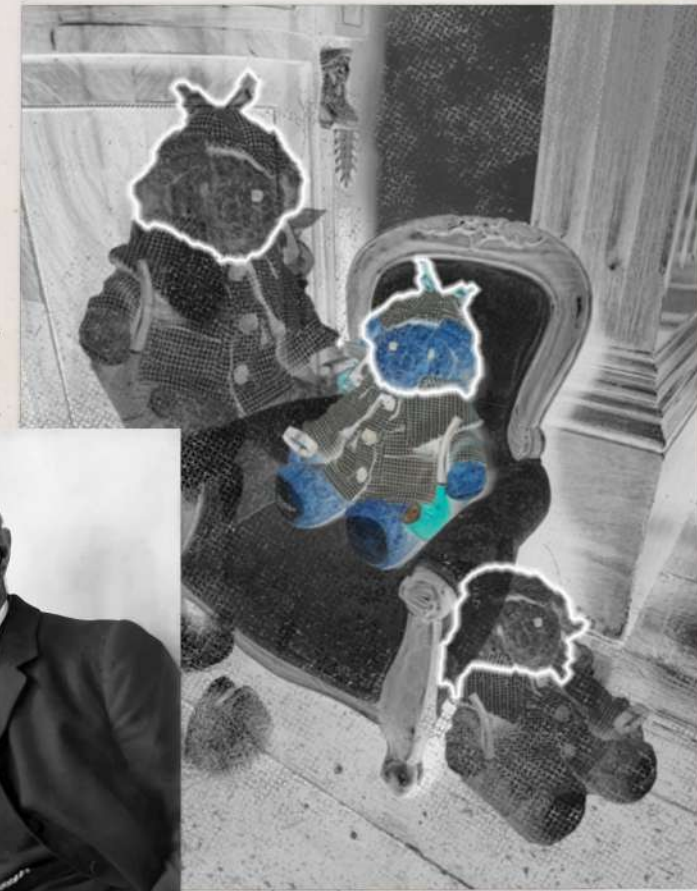
Egyptian Hall. (1887). Epps's Cocoa Programme [Image].



Beaton, C. (1920s). Self Portrait [Photograph].

His father, Charles Altamont Doyle, was a painter and illustrator. He struggled with alcoholism and mental illness for many years, and later spent time in a mental hospital. During this period, he created many watercolour paintings, often showing fairies, mythical scenes and imaginary creatures.

Doyle, C. A.
(c. 1885-93).
Meditation,
self portrait
[Image].



Benington, W. (1914). Sir Arthur Conan Doyle [Image].

Conan Doyle created Sherlock Holmes, a detective known for reason, evidence and logical deduction. However, in the later part of his life, Doyle himself became a firm believer in Spiritualism. He believed that the dead could communicate with the living through mediums.

After the First World War, Doyle's belief in Spiritualism became even stronger. The war caused a huge number of deaths, and he also lost family members and friends. Doyle believed that Spiritualism could comfort people who had lost loved ones, because it offered the idea that life continued after death.

Do Spirits Return?

Wasilevich, B. (1946). Jimmy
"One Eye" Collins After
Arraignment [Image].



Pierson, J.
(1992). The
Lonely Life
[Image].

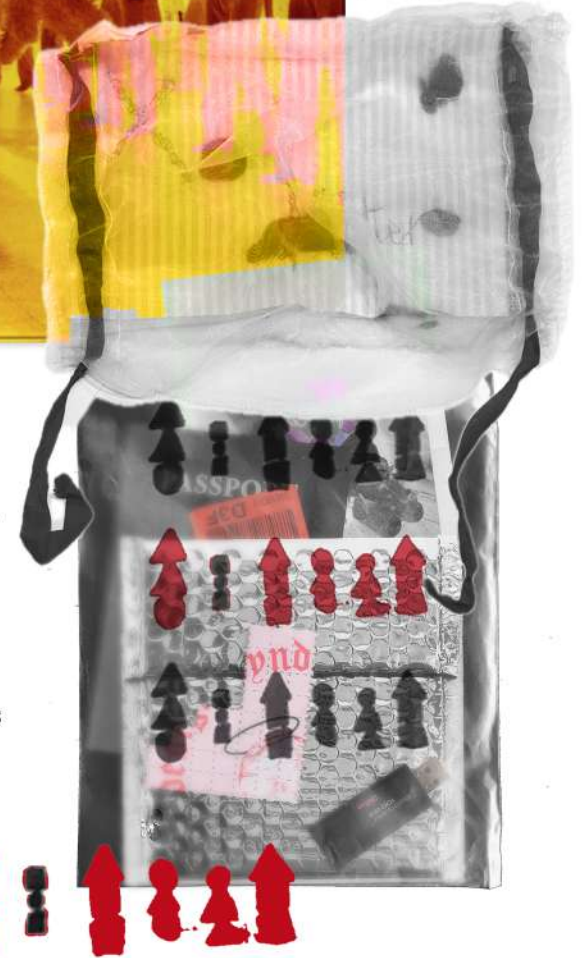


Bong, J. H. (2003). Memories
of Murder [Film still].



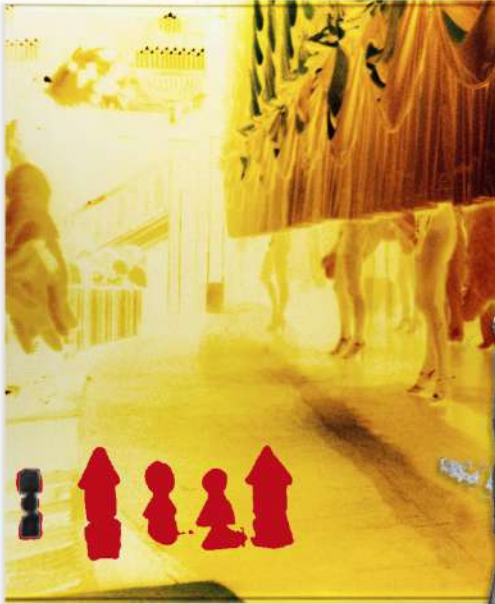
The theme of this page is concealment. After committing a crime, criminals often try to hide themselves, their actions or the evidence. This hidden information becomes the mystery that a detective needs to uncover.

In response to this idea, I created a sample with a small mechanism. When the drawstrings on both sides are pulled, the red embroidered text underneath, "X is killer", and the eye is revealed. I also made a small plastic bag containing crime-related objects. The front of the bag uses a code design that I created, which translates as "murder".





Colour Palette



Pierson, J. (1992). The Lonely Life [Image].

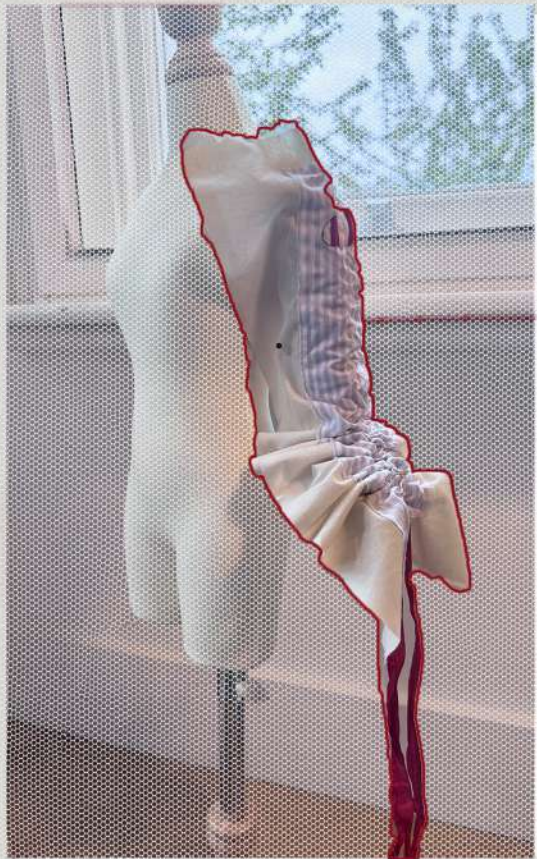


when the drawstrings are pulled up, the hidden information underneath is revealed. The process of solving a case works in a similar way. A detective gradually removes each layer of uncertainty to discover the truth. Therefore, in this part, I developed my design through gathers and drawstrings.

Concealment and drawstrings:



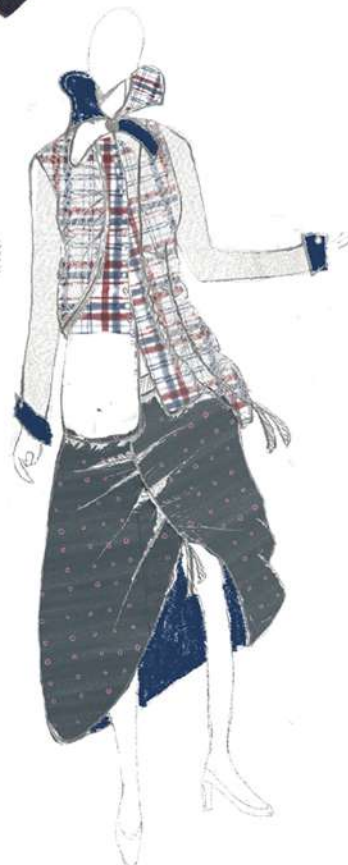
Journal des Demoiselles. (1884). Mode de Paris [Image].



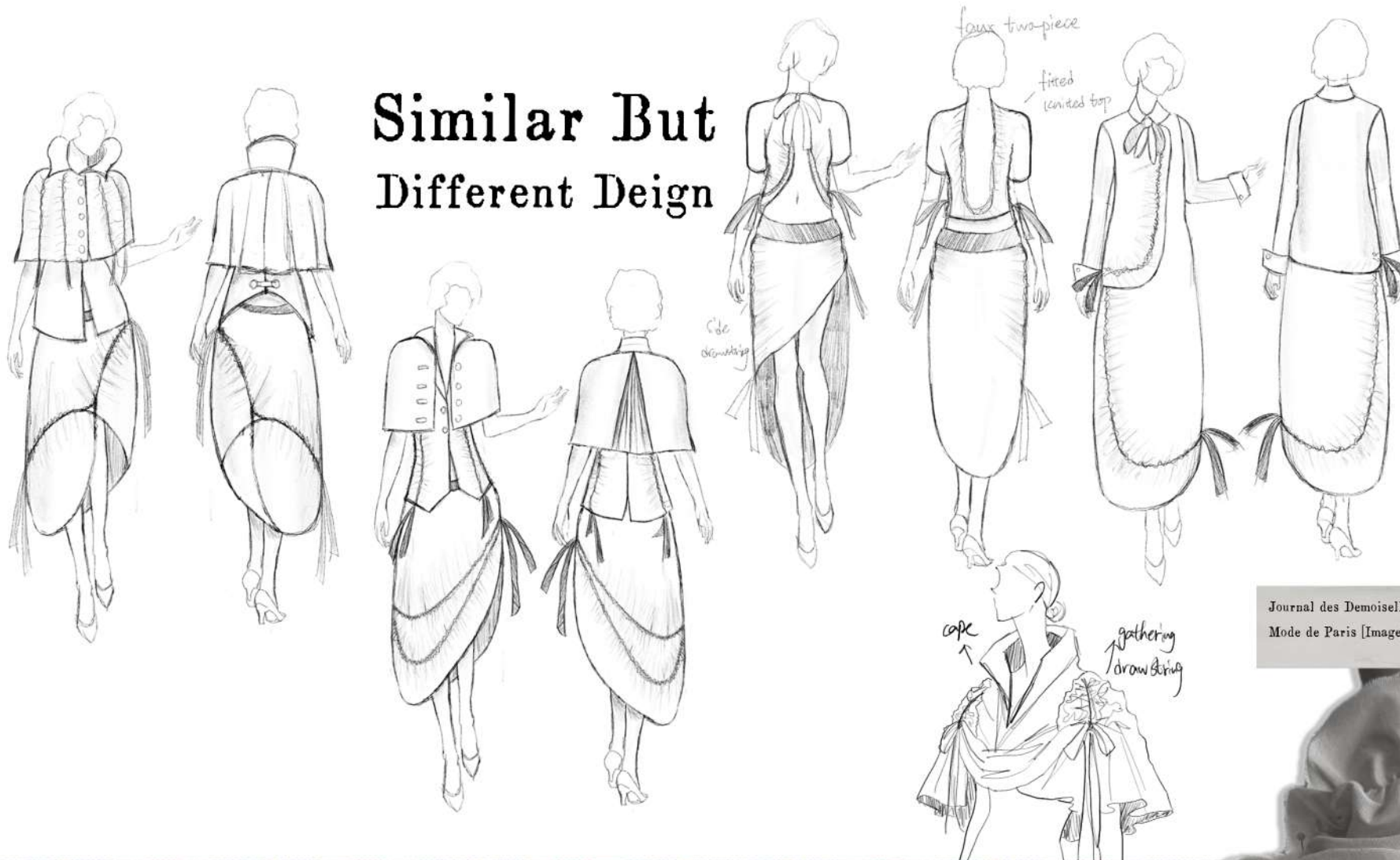
Drawstring Pull-up state



Drawstring Released state

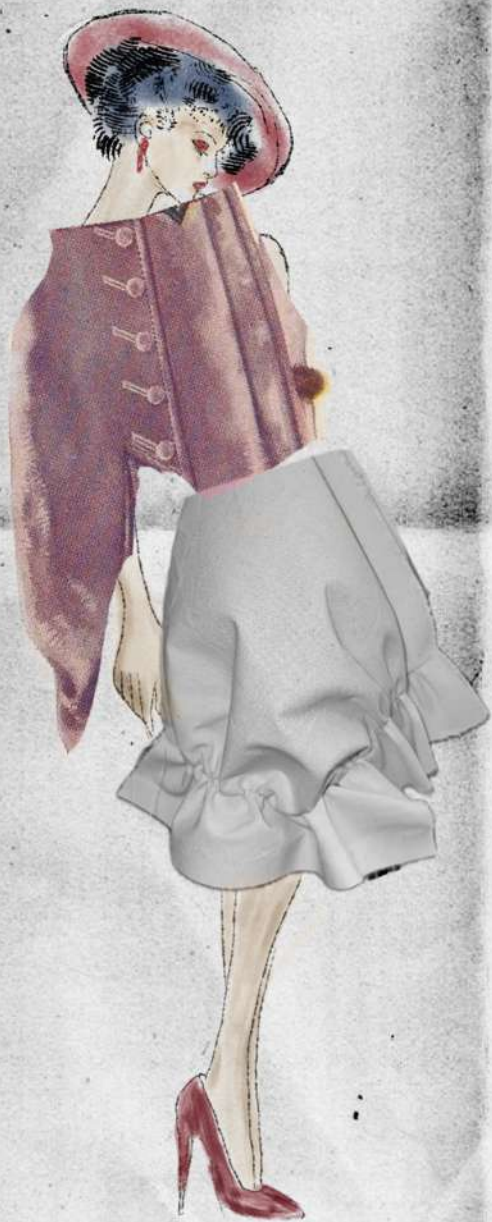


Similar But Different Deign



Journal des Demoiselles. (1884).
Mode de Paris [Image].

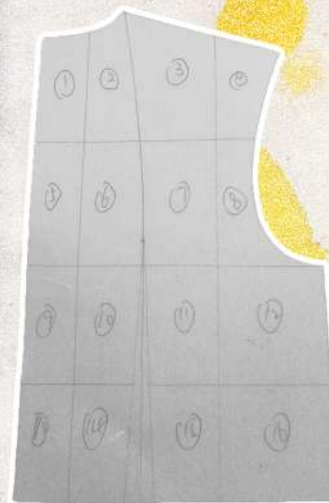
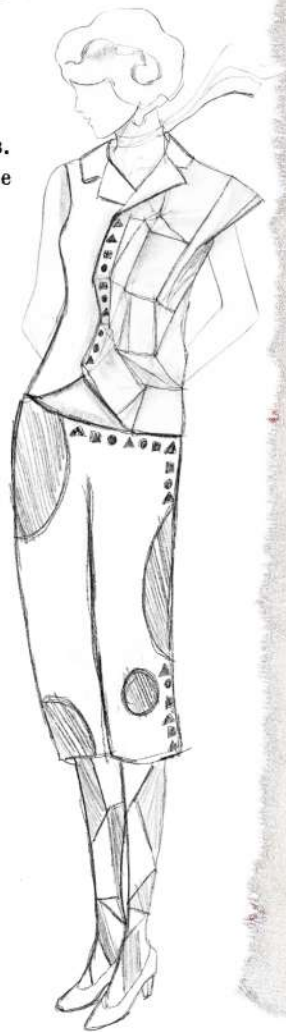


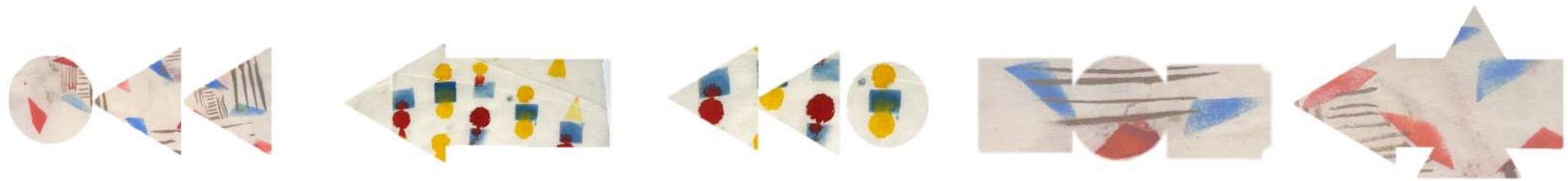


Puzzle

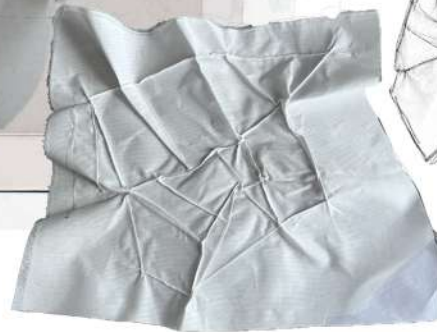
solving: code

When the detective pulls up the drawstring, he discovers a hidden sequence of coded symbols. I took inspiration from the shapes of the code and inserted triangles and quadrilateral forms into the basic pattern block. Through this process, I developed new pattern pieces with a stronger three-dimensional structure.



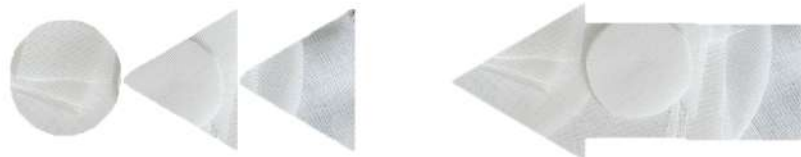
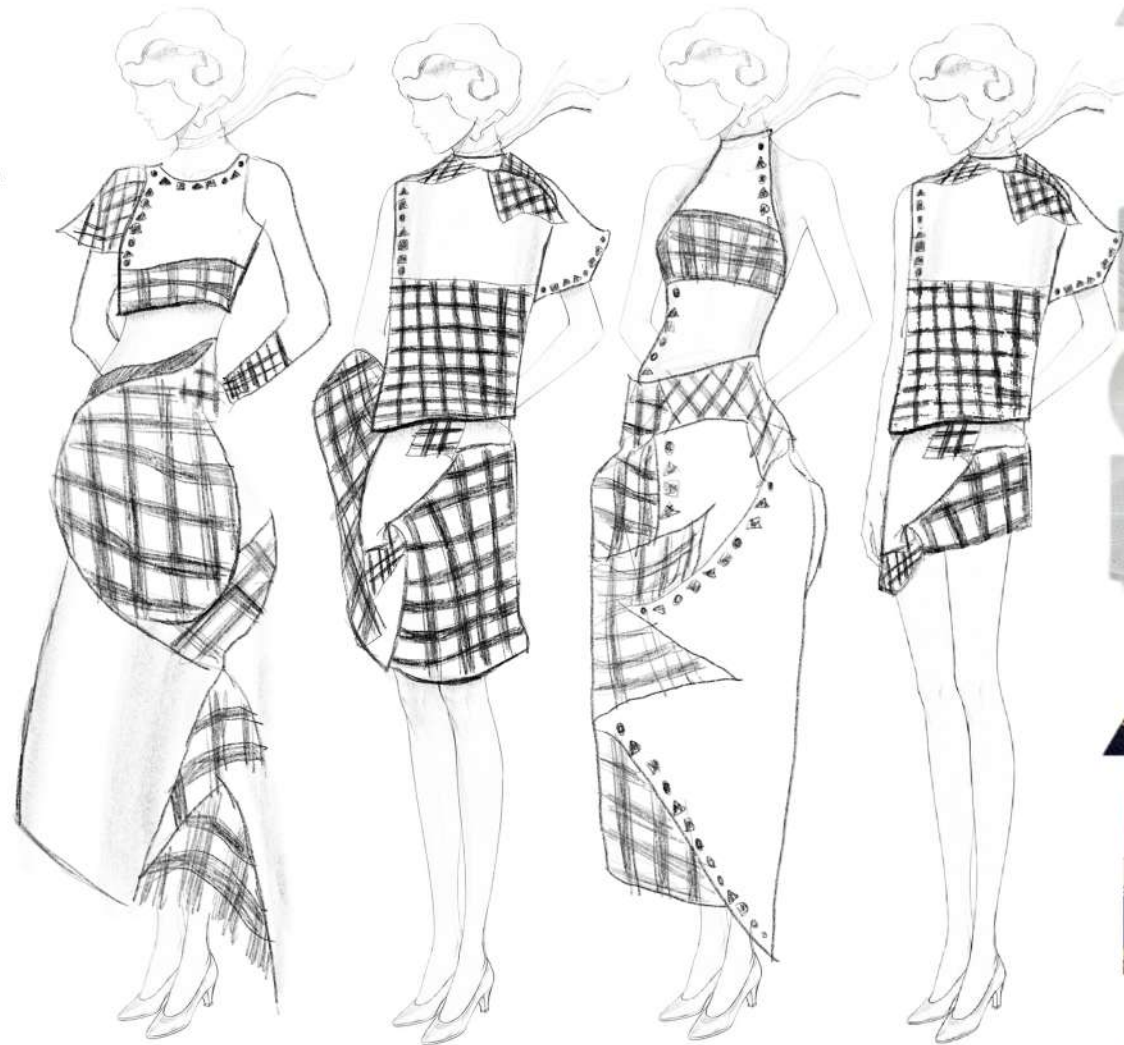


I continued to develop the code into different print designs and used clipping masks to place them into the layout. I also connected a square piece of fabric through triangular and quadrilateral shapes, then stitched along the edges to make the surface more three-dimensional.



Similar But Different Design

I cut two different fabrics into circles, triangles and squares in various sizes, using the basic shapes from my code system. I then randomly stitched the edges together to create new pattern pieces. After that, I placed them on the mannequin to experiment with different garment shapes.



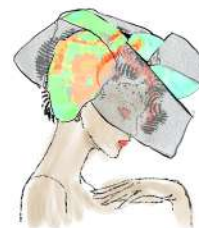
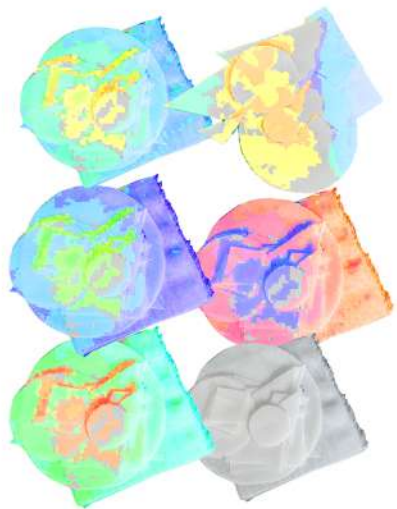


On this page, I focused on developing the design details, especially the sleeves, shoulders and neckline. I changed the traditional seam lines into geometric shapes, so the construction details could connect more closely with my code system.

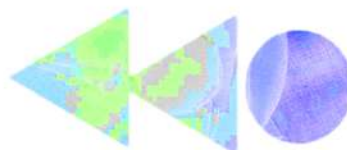


Details

Similar but different hat designs



While arranging the layout,
I found that adjusting the
hue and saturation of the
original white fabric created
unusual colour patterns. I
then added these new
patterns into the design
series.

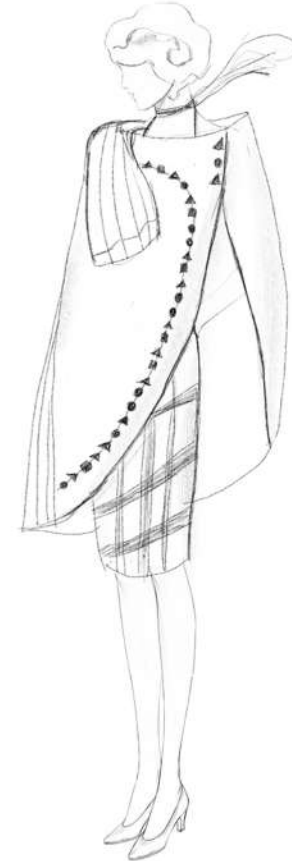
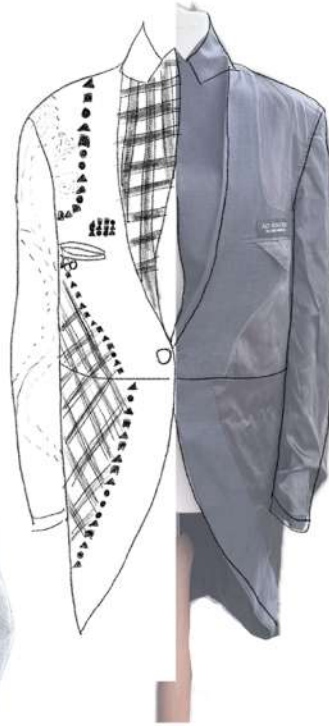




Abnormality

I took inspiration from Spiritualism. Supernatural phenomena are outside ordinary experience, and crime itself can also be seen as a departure from the normal. Therefore, my key word became "abnormality".

I turned the suit inside out, so the lining, which is usually hidden inside, became the outer surface. I then stitched two suits together with the linings facing outward and used them for unconventional draping on the mannequin.





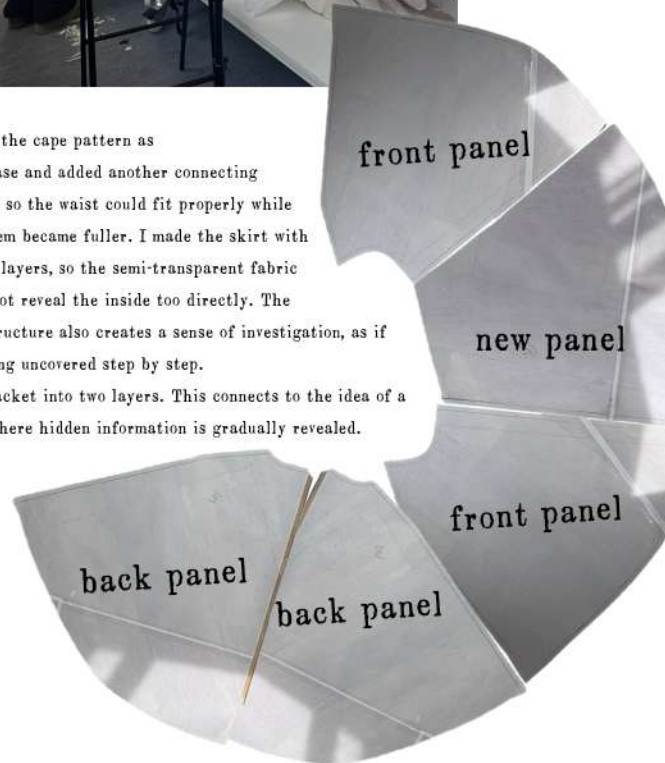
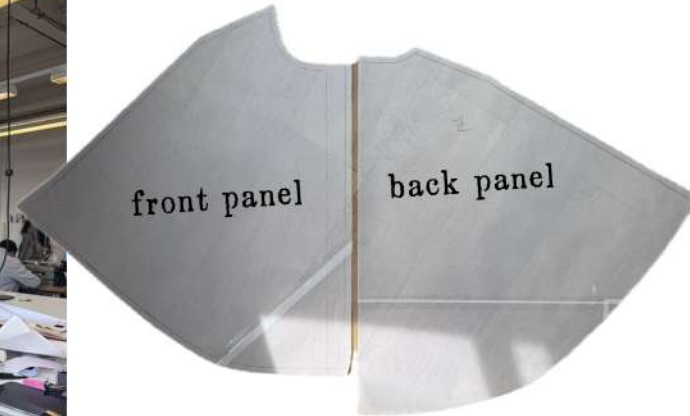
Line up



Garment Making for the Fashion Show

I used the cape pattern as the base and added another connecting panel, so the waist could fit properly while the hem became fuller. I made the skirt with three layers, so the semi-transparent fabric would not reveal the inside too directly. The layered structure also creates a sense of investigation, as if the truth is being uncovered step by step.

I also opened the front placket into two layers. This connects to the idea of a detective solving a case, where hidden information is gradually revealed.





For the waistcoat, I first experimented with a small basic pattern block. I moved the waist dart from the centre to the side, then divided it into eleven sections to add pleats. This allowed me to create a drawstring effect on the side of the waistcoat.





On the fashion show day
Model: Jia Xie
Photographer: Talia Yang